tried to show you the extent to which it grew out of my personal history, but a great deal of it, too, came from thinking hard about what to do. I'm told by industry-watchers that thinking is no great aphrodisiac when it comes to celebrity memoirs: then so be it, let us agree to let this book fail as a celebrity memoir. The work of WikiLeaks that would become so famous was born, and continues to be born, out of a passion for new ideas about how global society might go about protecting freedom. It is also born from the application of a scientific frame of mind to the issue of rights.

What are rights, anyway? Rights are freedoms of action that are known to be enforceable. A right therefore implies an equal responsibility. I don't mean this in the way that right-wing journalists mean it when they say that a petty thief has forfeited his rights because he didn't meet his responsibilities. I mean that if we recognise that somebody possesses a right, we must also recognise our own responsibility to protect that right. As I write these words, children are dying of starvation. I may proclaim the right of every child to freedom from hunger but if I stand by while they starve, my words are worthless. And yet some rights go unrealised, unenforced. An oppressive state squeezes dissidents, tries to make them small, to lock them up, to isolate them – all in an attempt to diminish their right to speak until they are alone, chatting to themselves in an empty room. And to return, therefore, to our goal of justice with a seemingly banal but truly fundamental observation: we cannot realise the basic rights that underpin justice in a world of concealment, secrecy and lies. It is the right to know that draws forth the right to speak. And, taken together, we can call these two rights the right to communicate knowledge.

We should remember that the decision about which rights will be enforced, and which shall be ignored, is always a matter of politics. To put it baldly: I have a single goal, not a very original one but a definite goal to my life, which is to help in the creation of a more just society to live in. I am not for transparency all round, or even democracy all round, but I am for justice, and the contribution we are making is to argue the case for new inevitabilities when it comes to justice and technology. I believe we have an innate yearning for justice. We have an innate aversion to censorship. And the Web can speak to that.

We have a responsibility to knowledge. We have a duty to information. That is why we love our libraries. But, in the digital age, we might also understand that, finally, we have a responsibility to use our technology to